

CORE FORMULA

Tentative marker + specific interpretation + correction invitation. -> I may be reading this wrong: is the main concern [X], or is it more [Y]? -> Before I assume, do you mean [specific read]? -> Can I check whether this is about [topic], or something else? -> Tell me if I am off: are you looking for [support], [clarity], or [a decision]? -> Can I check my read — is it [A], [B], or neither?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Can I check my read before I respond?

BEST FOR

- Ambiguous statements where several meanings are plausible.
- Emotional conversations where a wrong label would irritate or shame the speaker.
- Workplace moments where motive, concern, priority or risk is unclear.
- Text or email threads where tone is easy to misread.
- Conflict, where you need to test your understanding before you respond.
- Coaching, feedback, support, mediation and debrief conversations.

PHRASE BANK

Everyday openers · Short everyday checks

- "Can I check what you mean before I jump in?"
- "Can I check my read before I respond?"
- "Hang on — can I check I have understood you right?"
- "I might be misreading this — is it the plan, the timing, or something else?"
- "Is the frustrating part what happened, or how it happened?"
- "Do you want me to take this as a big deal, or more as a quick vent?"
- "Before I assume, do you mean it that way?"

Two-option checks · Correctable A-or-B reads

- "Can I check my read — is it this, that, or neither?"
- "Is the frustrating part the plan, or the way it landed?"
- "Is it more hurt, frustration or disappointment — or something else?"
- "Are you saying I missed the mark, or that the constraints changed?"
- "Is this a blocker, a risk to monitor, or a preference?"
- "Is the main issue confidence, clarity, or choosing between priorities?"
- "Do you mean it as a criticism, or as a suggestion?"

Workplace / professional · Meetings, decisions and reviews

- "Before I respond, can I check the concern you want me to address?"
- "Is the risk you are flagging mainly quality, timing, cost, or stakeholder trust?"
- "I hear a possible concern about ownership. Is that accurate?"
- "Are you asking for a decision, a sounding board, or just visibility?"
- "Can I check the frame — are we reviewing quality, alignment, or next steps?"
- "Before I plan around this, is it a hard blocker or a preference?"
- "Is this feedback on the direction, or on the detail?"

Digital / text · When tone is hard to read

- "Tone is hard to read here — are you asking for input, or just flagging this?"

- "Before I assume, is this a blocker or a heads-up?"
- "Checking my read: do you need action from me, or just awareness?"
- "Is your main concern the deadline, or the decision path?"
- "Reading this cold — is the tone frustrated, or just brief?"
- "Quick check so I do not misread: urgent, or when-you-can?"

High-pressure / conflict · Before you get defensive

- "I do not want to put words in your mouth. Is the issue the decision, the process, or both?"
- "Let me check before I react: are you saying I missed the mark, or that the constraints changed?"
- "I may be off. Are you asking me to explain, fix, or just acknowledge it?"
- "Before I defend anything, what is the part you most want me to understand?"
- "Before I explain, did that land as unclear, unfair, or too abrupt?"
- "Before I get defensive — what is the actual thing you need me to hear?"

Sensitive / emotional · Careful checks about feeling

- "I want to be careful with this. Is it more hurt, frustration, disappointment, or something else?"
- "Would it be right to say this felt dismissive, or is that not quite it?"
- "I am not trying to analyse you. I just want to check I understood the impact."
- "Is it okay if I test a read, and you can correct it?"
- "Are you annoyed, tired, or just keeping it brief?"
- "I might have this wrong — did that feel like being overlooked, or something else?"

Repair / reset · When you have already misread

- "I think I jumped ahead — can I check what you actually meant?"
- "Let me back up. Did I misread that, or just the emphasis?"
- "I may have put words in your mouth. Say it your way and I will follow."
- "That came out more like a conclusion than a question. What did you mean?"
- "I do not want to over-interpret this. What should I take from it?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Friend says "Whatever, it is fine." You reply: "You are clearly angry."
Better: "Are you annoyed?"
Best: "I might be misreading this — is it actually fine, or does something still feel unresolved?"
- Weak: Colleague says "This process is not working." You reply: "You just do not like the new system."
Better: "Is this about the system?"
Best: "Before I assume, is the issue the system itself, the handoff, or the decision rights around it?"
- Weak: Partner says "You always do this." You reply: "That is unfair."
Better: "What do you mean?"
Best: "Let me check before I react — are you saying this is a pattern, or that this moment hit a sore point?"
- Weak: Client writes "Concerned about the timeline." You reply: "We can still deliver."
Better: "What concern?"
Best: "Checking my read: is it the final date, the milestones, or confidence in the path?"

DECISION TREE

If You are about to infer motive, emotion, meaning, priority or intent

If not, just listen or respond directly. If so, treat the read as a guess and continue.

"Can I check my read before I respond?"

If They have already stated the meaning clearly

Do not re-interpret — reflect, validate, summarise or act on what they actually said.

"So the main thing is the timeline — have I got that right?"

If Your read could embarrass, accuse, diagnose or corner them

Soften and ask permission before you offer it.

"Is it okay if I test a read, and you can correct me?"

If You can make the read specific and easy to correct

If yes, offer one or two options with an exit. If no, ask a broader clarifying question instead.

"Is it more the workload, the timing, or something else?"

If They correct or reject the read

Accept the correction cleanly and update. If they close down, stop interpreting and switch to listening, apology or a boundary.

"Got it — I will drop that read."

If The meaning is now clear — pick the next move

Feeling -> emotional labelling; concern -> validate it; ambivalence -> double-sided reflection; deeper value -> meaning reflection; next action -> a clean request.

"Okay, so what would actually help here is..."

SCENARIOS

A friend sounds short with you

You might be reading irritation into brevity — check the tone without accusing. — "I may be misreading the tone — are you annoyed, tired, or just keeping it brief?"

A team member criticises a plan

The issue could be quality, process, ownership or risk — offer specific options. — "Is the concern the timeline, the owner, or the risk we are carrying?"

A partner says "never mind"

It could mean closed, hurt, tired or overwhelmed — check consent and meaning. — "Do you want to leave it there, or is there something I am missing?"

A client flags a concern by email

Digital tone is under-specified — clarify the category before you respond. — "Checking my read: is this a blocker, a risk to monitor, or a preference?"

A feedback conversation gets tense

Do not assume defensiveness — check how it landed before you explain. — "Before I explain, did my feedback land as unclear, unfair, or too abrupt?"

A coaching conversation

You have a possible pattern but not enough evidence — test it gently. — "Can I test a read? Is the main issue confidence, clarity, or choosing between priorities?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person has already clearly stated what they mean.
- Immediate safety or emergency action takes priority.
- You are using the check to delay accountability.
- They have signalled they do not want to be analysed.
- Your "check" is really a leading accusation.
- The moment needs a direct apology, boundary or decision, not more interpretation.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot your reads

Through one day, notice every time you silently decide what someone meant, felt or intended. Jot down five of these snap interpretations.

Day 2 — Write them as claims

Take five real statements you might hear and write the risky interpretation as a flat claim, e.g. "You are angry because I changed the plan."

Day 3 — Convert to checks

Rewrite each claim as a check: tentative marker + specific read + a "something else" option, e.g. "I may be reading this wrong — is the change the problem, or the lack of notice?"

Day 4 — Add correction power

Add an easy correction invitation to each check — "tell me if I am off", "or is it something else" — then read them aloud

and cut any that sound diagnostic, superior or leading.

Day 5 — Rehearse the recovery

For each check, practise accepting a correction cleanly: "Got it — I will drop that read," with no defence of your first guess.

Day 6 — Use it live, once

In a real conversation, use the minimum viable move a single time: "Can I check my read before I respond?" Notice whether they relax.

Day 7 — Two-option and chain

Use a two-option check ("Is it more A or B?"), accept the answer, then chain into the right next move — label the feeling, validate the concern, or make a clean request.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the moment I was about to interpret?
- Did I mark my read as a guess, not a fact?
- Was the check specific enough to answer in a sentence?
- Did I give them easy power to correct me?
- Did I accept the correction without defending my first read?
- Did the check lower defensiveness, and did I chain into the right next move?